

Blu Ray: The real point is, the readers came, the recorders came, a few titles came. But nothing really seems to have come of it...

of notebooks, the first to include a Blu-ray drive: the Sony VAIO AR can display movies at full 1080p resolution. September, Panasonic unveiled the world's first Blu-ray Disc (BD) recorders. These support both BD-RE (recordable) and BD-R.

Now, they were planning hundreds of movie titles for Blu-ray by year's end, but that's hardly happened. The titles were few and far between, hardly compelling reasons for getting a player: August 31, MGM Home Entertainment announced four BD releases slated for release in November. Twentieth Century Fox, too, announced its first Blu-ray releases the same day. November, Twentieth Century Fox released *X-Men: The Last Stand* on BD.

The real point is, the readers came, the recorders came, a few titles came. But nothing really seems to have come of it. Why would one invest in an (expensive) Blu-ray laptop for backups? Or for a few movies? And what if Blu-ray turned out to be the wrong choice? When would the right time to upgrade be? Or, what if a new format were to trounce the other two?

That new format might well be HVD, Holographic Versatile Disc. We've spoken about holographic storage technology several times before, and now we find there's even an HVD Alliance (www.hvd-alliance.org). A TB of data on a regular-sized disc. Twenty times Blu-ray's capacity.

Why not just wait for HVD? The future's anything but crystal-clear.

DISPLAYS

"Booming sales of flat-panel television displays is leading to unprecedented research and development in the sector with the promise of new technologies designed to capitalise on market demand." That's from a business news article, and pretty much sums up 2006 where displays are concerned.

From a forum: "I feel that LCoS and DLP both have better pictures than Plasma or LCD sets. The picture just seems warmer." Typical 2006. Too many choices. Everyone's being too subjective. In fact, the LCD vs. Plasma battle seems never-ending—just try Googling "lcd plasma" and you'll get 14 million results as of this month—which is certainly indicative. ("crt lcd" gives only a million and a half!)

2006 was the year of choices; the year of new technologies, as in new technologies being advertised and sold; and in India, the year of the LCD beginning to gradually replace the CRT. 2006 was also the year of widescreen making it big. Even big made it big: the idle rich in India were able to shop right here for huge displays.

Even we simple folk had 20-inch and 24-inch flats-screen aspirations.

So what are all those choices we're talking about? As of today, if you want to buy a display, you can choose between CRT, LCD, LCoS, DLP, SED, and Sony's offering, SXRD.

One thing that mildly surprises us is that nobody seems to be doing anything to make CRTs—even flat CRTs—any better!

Now consider ad pitches like "virtually no motion artefacts or image streaking." "Strikingly clear, non-pixelated images with perfect geometry." What are these for? Any of the above-mentioned technologies, is the answer! Well, LCDs do suffer from streaking, but the degree has been decreasing so rapidly, LCDs are now a very viable option for gaming, too.

Space doesn't permit a technical discussion of the different technologies, so here's about Sony's SXRD. We can't lay our hands on one, so all we can say is... over 2 million pixels per panel mean superior clarity. Smooth, film-like images are possible: there's a true sense of depth and dimension. Watching sports is like looking through a skybox window.

That was from an ad... we did that just to show you that they all seem to be saying the same thing! "Choices" certainly is the buzzword in 2006 display technology—apart from, of course, "HD."

So what do we do apart from gawk? A few things. First, remember that graphics cards and gaming consoles are sporting HDMI (a high definition, digital interface, with a single cable for video and audio), so you can use your LCD panel to its full potential. Second, remember that you



Sony's SXRD technology has gotten videophiles drooling



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